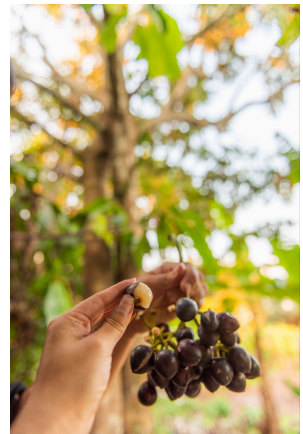


The meals here were wholesome and natural. Alongside Peru's beloved potatoes, the thoughtful cook offered a surprising variety of dishes—Chinese stir-fry, pasta, and plenty of fresh fruits and vegetables. One afternoon, our guide climbed a tree to pick Uvilla, a local fruit that looks like a grape but tastes like lychee—so good I found myself licking my fingers. Some nights we were treated to an extra dish: yellow-bellied piranha caught by our own hands. Fried to a crisp by our guide, the fish was fragrant, tender on the inside, and unexpectedly delicious. Dining on our self-caught meal gave the evening a special sense of ceremony.



When night fell, the rainforest came alive. If daytime was filled with birdsong and cicadas, then nighttime was an orchestra of its own—tree frogs, crickets, red howler monkeys, owls. The most striking sound, surprisingly, was the wailing call of a certain species of mouse. Back in our room after dinner, the lamplight revealed countless critters moving about—moths, cockroaches, and insects I couldn't begin to name. Anything edible had to be locked away, or the mice would steal it. I thought the cacophony would keep me awake, but like city dwellers who fall asleep to “rainforest ambience,” I drifted off within minutes.

